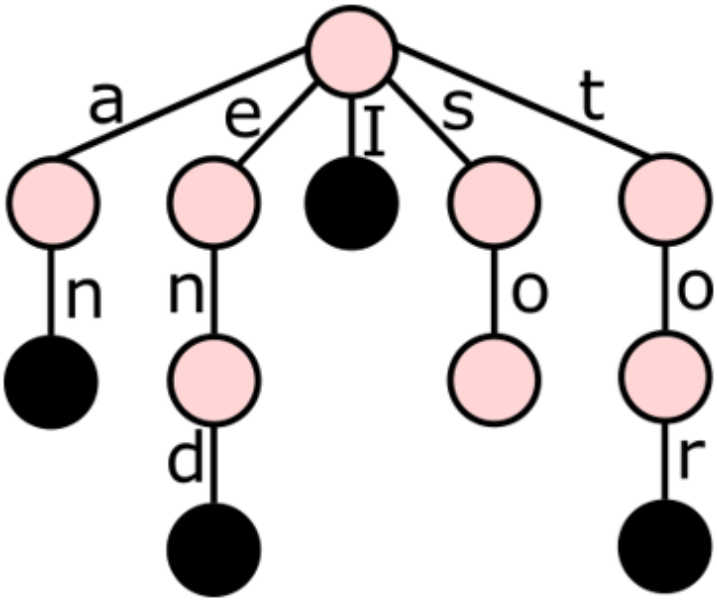


Figure 6.5 A degenerate trie, where no string shares a prefix with another string.

So much for space consumption: at worst, tries can be considered comparable to binary search trees. What about their running time? We will answer this question while looking at the individual methods, in order to also develop an understanding of how these results are derived.

6.2.2 Search

Let’s start with search: assuming we have built a proper trie, how do we check if it contains a certain key?

Turns out, it’s not too difficult, compared to a BST: the main difference is that we need to walk the tree one character (of the searched key) at the time, following the link that is marked precisely with that character.